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STRIVE FOR SELF-RELIANCE IN DEFENCE PRODUCTION

India's 'arms dependency' represents an acute vulnerability as far as national security and strategic autonomy are concerned

There is a huge irony in the fact that India, the world's second largest arms importer, also happens to possess one of the world's largest defence technology and industrial bases (DTIBs), comprising the vast Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO), with its network of 50 laboratories, backed by 16 Defence Public Sector Undertakings (DPSUs), including 41 ordnance factories recently 'corporatised' into seven DPSUs. Over the years, this complex has delivered an array of military hardware—warships, submarines, fighters, tanks, and aero-engines, two 'cherries on the cake' being the recent delivery of a 42,000-tonne aircraft carrier and a light combat helicopter, both designed and built in India.

What should temper national pride in all these platforms and systems, declared as 'indigenous', is the fact that major components, such as engines (whether diesel, gas-turbine or nuclear), guns, missiles and radars, as well as key micro-processor-based electronic components are of foreign origin. Representing 60-70 per cent of the platform/ system cost, these vital components render the availability of our weapons systems contingent on support from foreign sources of dubious reliability—especially in war.

There has been inadequate appreciation of the fact that this arms dependency represents an acute vulnerability as far as national security is concerned. As demonstrated by the Russia-Ukraine conflict, our dependence on both these nations for military hardware has eroded our 'strategic autonomy' and impacted our diplomatic freedom of action. The egregious failure of our government-owned DTIB represents not just security vulnerability but also an economic 'missed opportunity'. Thriving arms, aeronautics and shipbuilding industries could have made a dramatic contribution to India's economy by spawning ancillaries in the MSME sector, skilling our youth and creating jobs for them, and positioning India amongst major weapons exporters.

India's post-independence political establishment having failed to appreciate the need for self-sufficiency in military hardware, no roadmap has ever been drawn up to attain autonomy in defence production. Since the 1960s, India has poured billions of dollars into Soviet/ Russian coffers for weapons purchases, but no thought was given to leveraging these huge transactions to acquire advanced technology. The same playbook is being re-enacted while acquiring billions of dollars worth of American hardware, and India's laggard DTIB remains deficient in high technology. We must also honestly introspect as to how, starting from a similar base in the 1950s, the defence industries of Brazil, Turkey, South Korea and Taiwan have left India miles behind. China today is a major arms exporter and is engaged in serial production of modern aircraft carriers, destroyers, nuclear submarines, stealth aircraft and hypersonic missiles.

GETTY IMAGES



MAKE IN INDIA Army chief General Manoj Pande at a military expo, Jul. 28

Most prominent among DRDO projects that have attracted criticism for time/cost overruns and performance-shortfalls are the Tejas fighter and the Arjun battle tank. The inchoate Kaveri jet engine, which could have fathered a family of engines for indigenous military/ civil aircraft has, for unknown reasons, been cast into limbo, a decision India will regret forever. Collectively, these are indicative of not just the organisation's lack of focus but also of the absence of political vision and support, as well as inadequate user involvement. The exclusion of the private sector from defence production, to protect the DPSUs, has denied our DTIB huge advantages that would have accrued from such a dynamic partnership.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi's Make in India project having morphed into the laudable Aatmanirbhar Bharat campaign, our unhappy experience so far should prompt the government to ensure past mistakes are not repeated. There is also the need to recognise that while gimmicks like 'banned' and 'positive indigenisation' lists may make for good publicity, they contribute little to genuine fostering of technology. Among the measures that merit serious consideration are:

- Evolution of a 50-year Defence Production Strategy to spell out actions for a revamp and planned growth of DTIB.
- Creation of an independent ministry of defence production and re-structuring of DRDO to inject transparency, efficiency and accountability.
- Mobilising private sector as a full partner in defence R&D and production. ■

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